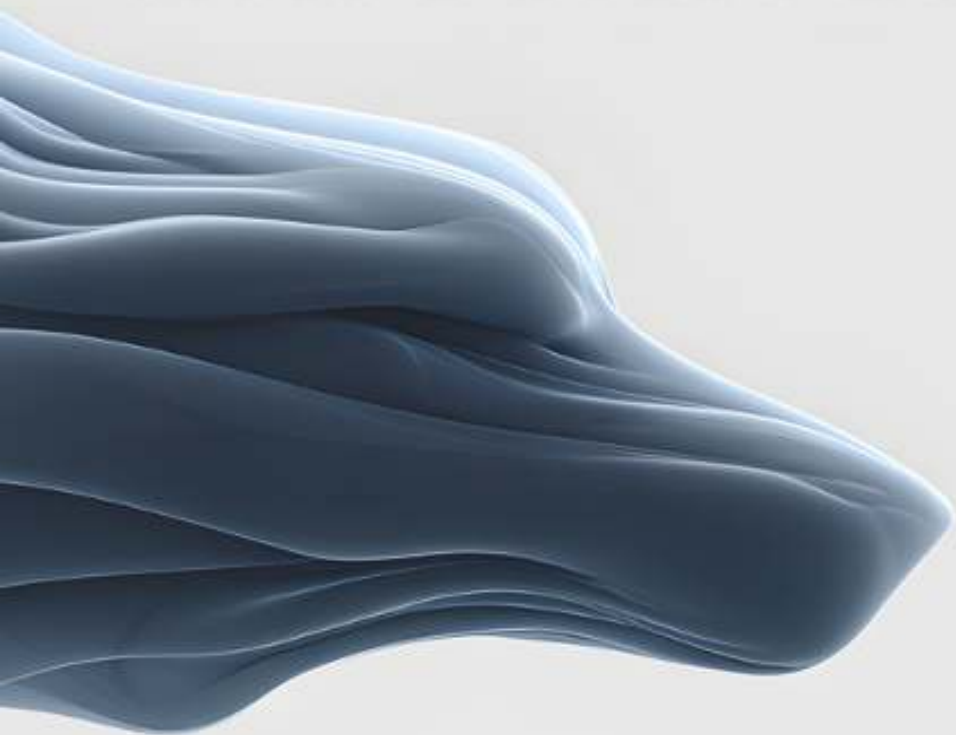


ROLL FOR INNOVATION



AI, creativiety and the dragon
we choose to see

KARL OTTO KRISTOFFERSEN

ROLL FOR INNOVATION

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE, CREATIVITY AND
THE DRAGON WE CHOOSE TO SEE

KARL OTTO KRISTOFFERSEN
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INTRODUCTION

SETTING THE SCENE FOR A NEW KIND OF ENCOUNTER

Artificial Intelligence (AI) is one of the most debated topics in the tabletop roleplaying game (RPG) space today. Some see it as a threat. Others treat it as a shortcut to publishing in a fast-moving marketplace. Many use it quietly, unsure of how openly they should talk about it.

The conversation around this topic often feels polarized, emotional, and difficult to approach with nuance.

This book grew out of that tension.

In 2024, I began writing a blog post about the use of AI in roleplaying games, but I never published it. At the time, the discussion felt too heated. There was little room for opinions other than “AI sucks,” and even asking open questions could feel like taking a side.

I have been part of this hobby for more than twenty-five years. My earlier published games, *Kvad* (2021) and *Sølvhjerte* (2024), were created without AI. They took years of steady work, filled with late evenings of writing, rewriting, and slowly shaping the text into something that felt finished.

Over time, life changed. With children, a demanding job, and a busy everyday rhythm, my creative time narrowed into small windows of opportunity such as lunch breaks, plane rides, and quiet hours after the house was quiet.

That was when I began experimenting with AI.

Not as a replacement for thinking, but as a way to keep working when time was constrained and energy was limited.

The result was surprising.

This book exists because I believe the conversation around AI needs more room for reflection. Not to defend it, and not to condemn it, but to understand it better.

These pages look at earlier technological shifts and how people reacted to them. They explore what AI can and cannot do, and touch on responsibility, transparency, and why human judgement remains central to creative work.

This is a short book, meant to be read in one or two sittings. It does not aim to settle the debate, but to slow it down, and make room for thought and conversation.

And then there is the title.

In roleplaying games, rolling for initiative is a ritual that marks the start of a conflict. A die is rolled, and from that moment, the situation must be faced, whether it was wanted or not.

Roll for Innovation reflects that moment. AI has entered creative work. The die has already been rolled, and the outcome is uncertain. This book explores what that uncertainty may mean for us as creators, and for the RPG hobby as a whole.

Reading this, you probably have one question lurking in the back of your mind. Was this book written with AI?

You will find the answer in the final chapter.

If any of this feels useful or worth discussing, feel free to pass it on, or leave a review for others who may be standing at the same crossroads.

For now, let us begin.

CHAPTER 1

FEAR OF A BLACK DRAGON

WHY POWER WITHOUT RESTRAINT FEELS THREATENING

In Norse mythology there is a story about Fáfnir, a dwarf who became a dragon after taking possession of a powerful treasure. Consumed by greed, he killed his father, withdrew from the world, and slowly transformed into something monstrous.

He became a warning of what happens when great power continues to act after human intention has disappeared.

New technologies seem to follow a similar pattern. They arrive suddenly, before anyone has time to adjust. Their impact is felt immediately, while their true purpose becomes clear only later. People react to the shock long before the shape of change can be fully understood.

History shows this pattern repeatedly.

When the printing press appeared in the 1400s, scribes feared for their livelihood, and religious leaders worried that knowledge would slip out of their control.

When photography arrived in the 1800s, portrait painters felt threatened by a device that

captured in seconds what had once taken days or weeks. Critics questioned whether painting itself had a future at all.

Then came the industrial revolution. Machines reshaped societies on a scale no one had seen before. Growth came quickly, and it came with pain. Many traditional professions disappeared, while new roles emerged as engineers, operators, and designers. The shift was uneven, disruptive, and deeply transformative.

AI enters the story as a new chapter. It does not arrive as a single machine or invention, but as a system that produces language, images, and structure at a pace no individual can match. That scale unsettles the world of artists. Not only because it challenges the link between effort and creativity, but because it raises deeper fears about relevance, livelihood, and whether human work will still matter in a world where machines can produce so much, so quickly.

History, however, suggests a hopeful way to look at this fear.

The printing press did not remove human thought or authority. It shifted who could read, interpret, and challenge ideas, and made movements like Martin Luther's Reformation possible by allowing texts to spread beyond institutional control.

Photography did not end painting. By removing the need to document reality, it opened the door to movements like Impressionism and later Expressionism, where mood, perception, and emotion mattered more than accuracy.

Industrialization did not replace the need for humans. It displaced certain kinds of labor while creating new roles that still depended on judgement, skill, and responsibility.

Methods changed, but the human role in choosing, judging, and creating meaning remained. Seen through this lens, AI does not replace creativity, it challenges how it is expressed.

Much like Fáfñir, fear follows when power appears suddenly and without restraint. His transformation was immediate and dangerous, marked by violence and irreversible consequences. There was no time for reflection, only reaction.

I believe AI stands in a similar place today. Powerful and still unfolding, it is feared for understandable reasons.

Like all great power, what it becomes depends on how we choose to face it.

CHAPTER 2

BEHIND THE SCREEN

A PRACTICAL LOOK AT HOW AI ACTUALLY WORKS

AI can feel almost magical when it produces text or images in seconds. It answers confidently, writes fluently, and rarely hesitates. This makes it easy to imagine intention, intelligence, or creativity behind the output.

In reality, its power is far more ordinary.

AI is not a mind, an author, or an artist. It does not understand ideas, stories, or meaning. It is a system trained to recognize patterns and predict what is likely to come next.

A language model, a type of AI trained on large amounts of text, does not know what a dragon is, why a scene feels tense, or why a story touches those who engage in it. When you give it a prompt, it searches through patterns it learned during training and generates a response that statistically resembles a good continuation. If you ask it to describe a village, it produces something shaped like a village description. If you ask for a backstory, it predicts a backstory-shaped paragraph. The results can be convincing, but the process is still prediction, not understanding.

This distinction matters.

Yuval Noah Harari uses a useful example in his book *Homo Deus*, when describing computers trained to compose music in the style of Johann Sebastian Bach. To many listeners, the result sounds convincing. The structure is correct, and the harmonies follow familiar rules. But trained musicians notice that something is missing. The piece behaves like music without carrying intention.

The system reproduces the shape of creativity without sharing its purpose.

This difference is easy to miss. AI can learn how creative work is made while remaining disconnected from why it is made. That gap is where human judgement still lives.

When we mistake output speed for intelligence, we begin to assume that AI can replace human thought. It cannot. AI does not know what matters in your world or why one idea feels right while another feels hollow.

This is why human skill remains essential to creative work. Experience, taste, and judgement are not optional extras. They are the core of authorship. AI can organize, suggest, and smooth, but it cannot decide purpose or meaning.

Used well, AI can support a creative process guided by clear intention. Without direction, it will confidently guess its way forward.

Understanding this allows us to use the tool without projecting qualities onto it that it does not possess. It also sets the stage for the next question.

If AI does not think, but it does move very quickly, what happens to the pace of creative work when it enters the process?

CHAPTER 3

ROLLING WITH ADVANTAGE

WHY AI FEELS POWERFUL, AND WHY THAT MATTERS

Once you understand that AI does not think, the next question becomes harder to answer. If it lacks understanding, why does it feel so powerful?

The answer is speed.

AI removes friction from many parts of creative work. It drafts quickly. It rewrites instantly. It offers suggestions without fatigue or delay. Tasks that once took hours can now take minutes. This change in tempo alters how creative work feels, even when the underlying process remains human.

In tabletop terms, AI is like rolling with advantage. The odds shift, as you move faster, hit harder and recover from mistakes more easily.

This can be intoxicating. When progress happens quickly, it feels productive. Pages fill, ideas stack up and momentum builds. But momentum is not the same as direction. Moving faster does not guarantee that you are moving toward something meaningful.

This is where creative judgement becomes more important, not less. When you have more options to choose from, each decision becomes more meaningful. When drafts arrive instantly, sensitivity to the work itself replaces effort as the limiting factor. The work shifts from producing words to deciding which words deserve to stay.

This shift can feel uncomfortable. Many creators are used to effort being visible. Time spent struggling often feels like proof of value. When friction disappears, it can feel like something important has been lost, even if the result improves. That tension is real, and it deserves to be acknowledged.

At the same time, speed can open doors. It can help creators test ideas that would otherwise remain unexplored. It can lower the cost of failure and make experimentation less risky. When revision becomes easy, learning can accelerate. You can see more clearly what works by encountering what does not.

The question is not whether speed is good or bad. It is whether speed is guided.

Without intention, AI encourages forward motion without reflection. With intention, it becomes a way to focus effort where it matters most.

The difference lies in whether the creator remains present in the process.

Rolling with advantage does not mean winning automatically. It means you still need to know what you are trying to do, and why. AI can speed up the work, but it cannot carry the responsibility for the choices behind it.

Those choices are connected to fairness and consent. Who paid the cost of the training data? Who benefits from the output? And what kind of impact does AI have on the environment?

That is where the next chapter begins.

CHAPTER 4

ETHICAL BASTIONLAND

FAIRNESS, CONSENT AND RESPONSIBILITY

AI is not only a creative tool. It also raises ethical questions that sit at the center of today's debates. All of them deserve careful thought rather than quick conclusions.

One of the most discussed concerns involves training data. Models learn by studying vast collections of text and images, leaving many artists and writers feeling that their work was used without consent, compensation, or even awareness.

This raises a basic question of fairness.

If your work helps train a system that may later compete with you, should you have been asked first?

For many creators, this concern is not only about ownership, but about livelihood. Systems trained on years of human work may weaken the ability to earn a living from skills developed over time. Some frame this as borrowing, often pointing to the idea of “steal like an artist,” where learning through imitation is seen as a natural part of human creativity. Others describe the same process as theft.

These reactions differ in tone but share a common thread. Human effort is being absorbed at scale without consent, recognition, or security.

Environmental impact adds another layer. Using AI requires energy, and while a single prompt consumes little power, the picture changes at massive scale. Data centers already account for a significant share of global electricity use, and AI is becoming an increasing part of that demand.

In this sense, AI is better compared to air travel than to everyday electricity. A single flight can unlock remarkable possibilities, allowing people to connect, explore, and create in ways that would otherwise be impossible. At the same time, flying carries a real environmental cost, especially when multiplied across millions of trips.

AI works in much the same way. Individual uses may feel small and beneficial, but together they form a system with consequences.

Acknowledging this does not mean rejecting the tool. It means understanding what we take part in.

This chapter does not try to resolve these issues. Training data, energy use, and responsibility exist within a landscape of competing values. Artistic rights, creative freedom, fairness, and

technological progress all pull in different directions.

There are no perfect solutions here, only trade-offs.

One ethical question, however, touches everything discussed so far: transparency. If AI plays a role in creating something, should readers be told? Should they have the right to know?

That question deserves its own chapter.

CHAPTER 5

ILLUSION SPELLS

HOW TRANSPARENCY IS THE NEW HONESTY

Transparency sounds simple, but it carries emotional weight. Being open about using AI can feel risky. A creator may worry about being judged before anyone has engaged with the work itself.

Yet transparency is also the foundation of trust. Readers do not only buy a book. They enter a relationship with its creator, and that relationship depends on clarity and honesty.

From my experience, publishing platforms handle transparency in very different ways.

Amazon KDP uses a detailed disclosure system, allowing creators to specify how AI was used and to what extent. Editing, brainstorming, outlining, translation, and content generation can be marked separately.

This approach recognizes that AI can assist parts of a process without defining the entire work, and it preserves the distinction between using a tool and surrendering authorship.

DriveThruRPG (DTPRG) takes a much simpler approach. Its system is largely binary. A product must be labeled either *Handcrafted* or *Contains AI Generated Content*. I believe this removes nuance, as a book where AI influenced a single sentence receives the same label as one generated almost entirely by a model. A third option, *Creation Method Not Chosen by Publisher*, also exists for those who select neither.

When this labeling system was introduced in the summer of 2025, I was caught off guard. My *West Marches Guidebook* had already been published for months. Eventually a customer commented that they would prefer to know whether the content of the book was AI generated or not.

I opened the product page and saw the label sitting there, waiting for a choice under the new policy. My stomach tightened. It is striking how a few words on a screen can feel like an accusation.

For a moment, I hesitated. It would have been easy to select *Handcrafted* and move on. It would have been just as easy to leave the default option untouched and avoid the question entirely. Instead, I chose the option that reflected reality. I labeled the book *Contains AI Generated Content*, and I worried readers would

assume the work was rushed, low effort, or somehow dishonest.

That did not happen. The book continued to sell, and readers still valued it for what it was: a practical handbook shaped by deep research and real play at the table. A few even thanked me for being open about my process.

Trust did not weaken. It grew stronger.

That experience reshaped how I think about transparency. Being honest about AI is not about apology or justification. It is about giving readers the information they need to make their own decisions. A simple statement that says: this is how this was made.

If a reader then chooses to engage with the work, the relationship at least begins on honest ground. If they choose not to, that choice deserves respect as well.

Every book carries an unspoken agreement between writer and reader. It says: I will be clear about my process, and you may decide what that means to you. That trust is fragile. It grows slowly through openness and consistency.

Transparency protects that connection.

This tension has appeared on a much larger scale within the tabletop industry. In 2023 and 2024, Wizards of the Coast faced public backlash after AI generated art appeared in promotional material and freelance submissions. The issue was not only the images themselves, but the lack of clarity around how they were made. Fans felt misled, artists felt threatened and trust eroded quickly.

In response, Wizards introduced stricter internal guidelines, including a temporary pause on AI assisted art and closer review of creative submissions. Other publishers took different paths. Paizo updated its contracts to prohibit AI generated art and writing. Kobold Press publicly committed to keeping all creative work human made. These decisions were not about rejecting technology, but about protecting trust with their audiences.

To this day, many creators on DTRPG still hesitate to label their work, probably afraid of backlash or misunderstanding. The *Creation Method Not Chosen by Publisher* tag appears often, and the hesitation is understandable. But silence rarely builds trust. Openness does.

So, if AI plays a role in your creative process, being open about it can help sustain trust between you and your audience.

CHAPTER 6

IN THE EYES OF THE BEHOLDER

WHO DECIDES WHAT CREATIVE WORK IS WORTH

If AI speeds up the creative process, how does it affect the value of the work created with it? Should it be worth less simply because it took less time to make?

To think clearly about this, it helps to separate price from value. Price is what someone pays. Value is what the work gives in return. The ideas it sparks, the inspiration it provides, and the quality of play it creates at the table.

A short and inexpensive book can shape a campaign for years. Low price, high value. A large and costly hardcover can disappoint and end up gathering dust on a shelf. High price, low value. In other words, the time spent creating a book does not necessarily tell the whole story. What counts is the reader's takeaway.

We have faced similar questions before, often when new tools changed how art could be made. When photography made realistic depiction faster and easier, painting no longer needed to document reality in the same way. This shift helped give rise to modern art, where

emotional expression, abstraction, and conceptual ideas became central.

That change sparked strong debate. How could a loosely painted canvas be compared to the technical mastery of classical painters like Rembrandt? Where was the labor, the skill, the time? To some, modern art looked like a shortcut. To others, it represented a different kind of work, one less focused on technique and more on choice, intent, and meaning.

What these debates reveal is that value has always been shaped by how we understand effort, skill, and purpose. When methods change, those assumptions are challenged. The work may look different, but the question beneath it remains the same: what makes this matter?

AI complicates this discussion in a similar way. When outlining, rewriting, or editing takes minutes instead of weeks, it is natural to wonder whether something is lost along the way. Some discoveries that emerge slowly may appear less often. Some friction disappears. But a change in process does not automatically mean a loss of value in the result.

For a long time, creative value has been tied to visible effort. Spending years writing thick books with dense rules and complex systems. AI

unsettles that expectation. If some parts of the work take less time, does the book become less meaningful? Or does the real work simply move elsewhere, into judgement, intent, and care for the people who will use it?

A roleplaying game book is not valuable because it was difficult to make. It is valuable because it helps people imagine, play, and create together. If it supports memorable moments at the table, it has value. If it does not, no amount of labor can rescue it.

In the end, I believe creative tools do not decide what a book is worth. The readers do.

Value remains something experienced, not measured.

CHAPTER 7

BETWEEN TWO CAIRNS

FROM PERSONAL PLAY TO PUBLIC WORK

There is an important difference between using AI in private games and using AI in work you plan to publish. At home, creativity is a playground. The only real boundaries are your own comfort and the trust around the table. If AI helps you brainstorm a villain, write a speech, or generate a treasure table, it functions much like a random table or a dice roll. Nothing is being sold, and no wider audience is being asked to rely on how the work was made.

Publishing changes that context. The moment you sell something, expectations emerge. Readers want to know what they are buying and who made it. Some choose books based on genre, game system, or hype alone. Others care deeply about human authorship and process.

That distinction became clear to me one evening, a few beers in, after a long day at an RPG convention. Someone asked whether I felt guilty selling my *West Marches* books, knowing that AI had played a role in parts of the process.

The question surprised me.

Guilty is a heavy word, so I stopped and thought about what had gone into the book. The research, playtesting, and notetaking during games. The writing, revisions, layout, and design. Months of focused effort, guided by a clear intention to solve a problem and help others run better games.

The answer that formed was quite simple.

No, I did not.

I knew how much of myself was present on every page. My ideas. My judgement. My choices. My experience. AI had accelerated parts of the workflow, but it had not replaced the human core of the project.

Later, I realized that the question was not really about sales at all. It was about ownership. Was I comfortable calling the work mine when a tool had helped shape parts of it? Had using AI weakened my authorship, even if every meaningful decision still came from me?

Perhaps. But I was still proud of the book, and of the value it had brought to many players and tables.

That uncertainty does not belong to me alone. Many worry about how tools like AI might be used without care. If AI becomes a shortcut

rather than a support, it becomes harder to tell the difference between thoughtful work and content made only to fill space.

At home, those concerns rarely apply. No one needs to document tools on a character sheet or explain how an NPC was created. You are not selling anything. You are sharing a moment with friends. Private creativity can be messy, playful, and experimental, and AI can support that freedom without much consequence.

Publishing, however, is a public act. It enters a marketplace built on trust, where its process becomes part of the relationship between creator and reader. Even when a book is deeply human at its core, how it was made still matters.

Transparency does not limit that relationship. It protects it.

Using AI at home is largely about freedom, while using it in publishing carries responsibility. Learning to move between those two spaces may become one of the most important skills creators develop in the years ahead.

CHAPTER 8

NO FREE EXPERIENCE POINTS

WHAT AI MEANS FOR THE CREATIVE VOICE

A creative voice is not something you pick up from a tool. It forms slowly over time, through the books you read, the stories you write, the games you design, and the films, worlds, and ideas you absorb along the way. It grows through both creating and consuming, through trial, failure, and the gradual sense of what feels right.

A voice comes from experience, not efficiency.

The creative skill develops much like any other skill. It grows through time spent working on the craft. A widely known theory speaks about ten thousand hours as a rough marker for mastery. This is not a strict rule, but it points to something important. Skill is built through deliberate practice, mistakes, feedback and revision over time, until the doing of the skill starts to feel natural rather than forced.

Now add AI to that picture. Does the idea of ten thousand hours still apply when a tool makes progress faster and easier?

What AI seems to change is not whether friction exists, but where it appears. Instead of struggling with structure, formatting, or phrasing, effort can

move closer to decisions that actually matter. Feedback arrives faster, but it still needs to be understood. Suggestions appear instantly, but they still require judgement. The creator must decide what to keep, what to reject, and why.

In traditional creative work, friction often appears early. Much of the effort goes into finding the right words, shaping structure, and pushing the work forward step by step. Energy is spent getting something into form before deeper decisions can even be made.

Idea → Formulation → Structure → Decisions → Finished Work

With AI in the process, that pattern begins to shift. Tasks like formulation, structure, and execution can move faster, sometimes almost instantly. But friction does not disappear. It moves. Instead of struggling to produce options, creators face friction later, at the point of decision.

The effort shifts toward evaluating suggestions, choosing what to keep or reject, and understanding why one option feels right while another does not. The moments of resistance happen closer to the finished product.

In that sense, AI may accelerate learning not by removing effort, but by concentrating it. Some

obstacles fade, while others become sharper. The work becomes less about forcing words onto the page, and more about deciding what those words should truly do.

This acceleration does not affect everyone equally. If AI acts as a multiplier, it amplifies what is already there. A novice with limited experience may suddenly work at a higher level. That can be enough to produce something that looks impressive. An experienced creator, with years of practice behind them, may gain even more. In this way, AI does not flatten the field. It widens it.

This can feel uncomfortable, even unfair, especially to those who choose not to use such tools. That reaction makes sense. AI increases speed and output. A beginner may produce more, but without the experience to evaluate the results, the work will often still reflect an early stage. For experienced designers and writers, faster iteration can support sharper refinement. Their voice may become clearer rather than diluted.

The deeper question is not only about output, but about attention. The real risk may not be that AI replaces a creator's voice, but that speed makes it easier to stop listening to it. The slower parts of writing, hesitation, doubt, and reflection, are often where identity takes shape. When

suggestions arrive quickly and confidently, it becomes easier to move on before asking whether the words truly belong.

This does not mean AI must weaken the creative voice. It suggests that mindful presence matters more than ever. Reading closely. Questioning suggestions. Keeping the quirks that feel personal, even when they are inefficient. Judgement still has to be trained, and no tool can do that work for you.

AI can help you work faster, but it cannot give you a voice. The tool moves quickly, while a creative voice still grows at a human pace, shaped by experience and careful choices. A voice does not disappear because a tool exists. It fades only when the creator stops choosing deliberately.

As long as that difference remains clear, the voice remains human.

CHAPTER 9

SAVE VERSUS REPLACEMENT

WHAT AI AUTOMATES, WHAT STAYS HUMAN

When a new tool emerges, the same question tends to follow: what will this replace?

With AI, that question feels especially relevant. The tool is fast, flexible, and often surprisingly capable. It is easy to imagine it taking over large portions of creative work. But replacement is rarely a single moment. It is usually a gradual shift, shaped by what a tool does well, what it does poorly, and what it cannot do at all.

In the context of writing roleplaying books, this includes things like cleaning up language, checking grammar, reformatting text, summarizing notes, or generating lists of names. These tasks rely on pattern recognition rather than judgement. Letting a machine handle them does not remove creativity. For many authors, it simply frees attention for more meaningful decisions.

What remains is not replacement, but support. AI can help explore and refine ideas, but it cannot decide what belongs. Creativity comes from choosing what fits the book and the play experience, not from generating endless options.

This becomes clear when AI is asked to do more than assist.

A model can outline an adventure, but it cannot decide why the villain fits the setting. It can describe a city, but it cannot choose what emotions that place should evoke. Without human intention guiding those choices, the result often feels polished but empty.

AI also lacks memory in the human sense. It does not remember early drafts, abandoned ideas, or the long path that led to a final design choice. Many meaningful ideas in roleplaying games come from mistakes, misread rules, or half formed thoughts that turn into something unexpected.

AI tends to stay within known patterns. Humans regularly break them.

There is also the question of creative risk. Writing a roleplaying book often involves making choices that might not work. A strange mechanic, a personal tone or a rule that feels fragile but interesting. These choices matter because the author cares whether they succeed or fail. AI has no stake in the outcome. Without that stake, it cannot take meaningful creative risks and is limited to its own framework.

None of this means that change will be painless. New tools always reshape creative fields unevenly. Some tasks disappear. Others evolve. New roles emerge. But replacement is rarely total. Photography did not end painting. Calculators did not end mathematics. Word processors did not end writing. Each shift changed the craft, but the human core adapted.

AI will continue to automate parts of writing roleplaying books, and some of that will feel uncomfortable. But the center of the work, deciding what the game is about, how it should feel to play, and why it exists at all, remains human.

The tool can assist the process.
The purpose still comes from the author.

CHAPTER 10

ENTER THE DRAGON

HOW AI SHAPES THE HOBBY AND CULTURE AROUND IT

AI has entered the tabletop hobby. Some use it to brainstorm plot hooks or locations. Others use it to draft character backstories. Some designers use it to organize rules or edit text. The tool is no longer outside the hobby. It has become part of the creative environment.

The question is no longer whether AI belongs near tabletop games, but how it changes play, community, and the feeling of creating something together.

At its best, AI lowers barriers. It can help someone with dyslexia express ideas more clearly. It can help a non-native English speaker feel confident at the table. It can help a tired GM prepare a session after a long week. In these moments, AI does not replace creativity. It allows it to happen.

The risks appear when reliance replaces presence. If every Game Master (GM) leans on the same prompts, sessions potentially begin to feel alike. If designers depend on the same patterns, ideas lose their edge.

Tabletop games thrive on roughness, surprise, and improvisation. A tool that always aims to be correct can quietly smooth away the imperfections that make play feel alive.

There is also a social side to this, as tabletop games depend on presence. Players trust that a real person is paying attention, reacting, and shaping the story together with them. When the experience starts to feel cold and automated, that bonding experience may fade. AI can help with preparation, but when it replaces human judgement at the table, the game may lose something essential.

What keeps tabletop gaming alive is not efficiency. It is presence. The laughter after a bad roll. The pause before a risky decision. The moment a rule is misunderstood and the story takes an unexpected turn. These moments are not planned. They are shared. AI can help prepare for play, but it cannot create these moments on its own.

The same tension appears in publishing. Used carelessly, AI can flood marketplaces with material that looks finished but feels empty. Used thoughtfully, it can help creators focus on what matters most. The difference is not the tool, but the intention behind it.

AI is not going away. It will become more capable, more available, and more deeply woven into creative work. The future of tabletop gaming will include new tools, and pretending otherwise is neither useful nor honest. What matters is not whether these tools exist, but how they are used.

That future still belongs to people. It belongs to GMs who choose presence over automation, to players who value shared moments more than perfect outcomes, and to designers who remain thoughtful about their tools and honest about their choices. When intention guides the use of AI, it can support the hobby rather than dilute it.

The machine may join the party, but it does not lead it. The heart of tabletop gaming remains where it has always been: around the table, shaped by human judgement, imagination, and trust.

EPILOGUE

THE DRAGON WE CHOOSE TO SEE

Early in this book, I wrote about Fáfnir, the dwarf who became a dragon and frightened those who encountered him. His transformation happened faster than people could understand, and fear rushed in to fill the gap. In many ways, AI entered our world in a similar way: sudden, unfamiliar, powerful, and surrounded by uncertainty.

Across these chapters, we have tried to look more closely at the dragon. We have examined what AI actually is: a system built on patterns, fast but without intention. We have explored what remains human: judgement, emotion, purpose, and care. We have talked about transparency, trust, and about the fear that creativity might lose something essential if people stop listening to themselves.

And yet, AI offers something as well. For people with limited time, heavy responsibilities, or barriers that make traditional workflows difficult, it can help creative work survive.

For some, it does not replace creativity. It protects it.

Like every major creative tool before it, AI will eventually find its place. Not as a miracle, and not as a monster, but somewhere in between. Its shape will be determined not by fear, but by the choices people make as they use it.

When DTRPG introduced its AI labeling system, I learned about it from a reader who asked why my *West Marches Guidebook* was not marked yet. Enabling that label felt uncomfortable at first, not because I had done something wrong, but because I feared how the tool behind the work might be judged more harshly than the work itself. But readers stayed. The book continued to sell. Some even thanked me for the openness. That experience reinforced that honesty creates trust.

Which brings me to the question I promised to answer. Was this book written with AI support?

Yes.

Some sections began as late night drafts after my children were asleep. Others started as notes organized with AI during short breaks in the day. Parts of the text were written by hand, while others were written with AI and then revised or rewritten.

AI did not choose the structure of this book. It did not choose its tone, its message, or its personal stories. It did, however, help me keep moving when time was scarce and energy was low. The meaning behind the words is mine.

In games, rolling for initiative does not promise victory. It marks the moment where hesitation ends and responsibility begins. That is where we are now.

The dragon cannot be unseen. The die cannot be taken back. Innovation has already entered the room. What remains is our response.

Roll for Innovation is about what follows the roll. It asks how we remain human once uncertainty becomes part of the process.

Whether you choose to use these tools or not is up to you. I hope this book has offered a few perspectives to help you make that choice more thoughtfully, and to understand the choices others make.

Thank you for reading.

Karl Otto Kristoffersen